FREE SAMPLE · CHAPTERS 1-3

THE HOUSEPLANT RESET

Stop killing your plants, and learn to read what they actually need.



About This Sample

This is a free extract from **The Houseplant Reset**, a step-by-step system for keeping common houseplants alive.

The three chapters here are the ones that change the most for the least effort: why plants really die, how to read the light in your home, and how to water properly. Fix those three, and most plant deaths stop.

CHAPTER 1

Why Your Plants Keep Dying

You don't have a black thumb. Nobody does. What you have is a set of perfectly reasonable instincts that happen to be wrong for plants.

The three killers

Almost every houseplant death traces back to one of these:

1. Too much water. This is the leading cause of houseplant death by a wide margin. It's also the most frustrating, because it comes from caring too much. Roots need oxygen as well as water. When soil stays wet, the air spaces fill with water, the roots suffocate, and rot sets in. A plant with rotting roots can't take up water, so it wilts and yellows. That looks exactly like thirst, the owner waters again, and the cycle finishes the plant off.

2. The wrong amount of light. Usually too little. A room that looks bright to you can be very dim for a plant, and light falls away sharply with every step back from a window (Chapter 2). A plant in too little light can't use water or nutrients properly, so it grows slowly, stretches, and becomes much easier to overwater.

3. Sudden change. Moving a plant from a greenhouse to a shop to a car to your living room is a big shock. So is a cold draught, a radiator switching on, or being moved into strong direct sun. Plants adjust slowly, and sudden changes cause leaf drop that looks alarming but often isn't fatal.

Notice what's not on that list: forgetting to water now and then, pests, or not buying fertiliser. Those cause problems, but they're rarely what kills a plant. Kindness does more damage than neglect.

Why "easy" plants still die

Plant labels say things like "low light" or "easy care". Both mislead beginners.

"Low light tolerant" doesn't mean "likes low light". It means the plant survives dim conditions, growing very slowly. In a dim corner it uses water slowly too, so it becomes easy to overwater. Snake plants and ZZ plants are sold as indestructible. They're very tough, but they're killed by overwatering in dark corners constantly.

"Easy care" usually means "tolerates neglect". For attentive owners, that's precisely the problem. The plant needs less from you than you want to give it.

The shop-to-home slump

Most houseplants are grown in commercial greenhouses with bright light, high humidity, warmth and a steady supply of water and fertiliser. Then they travel, sit in a shop, and end up in a typical home, which is darker and drier than anywhere they've been.

It's normal for a new plant to drop a leaf or two, or pause its growth, for the first few weeks. That's acclimation, not failure. The mistake is reacting to it: repotting straight away, moving the plant every few days, or watering more to "help". Give it a stable spot and patience instead. Chapter 12 covers this in detail.

The reframe that fixes most problems

Stop thinking "what should I do to my plant?" and start thinking "**what is my plant telling me?**"

A plant can't ask for water. It shows you through soil moisture, leaf firmness, colour and growth. Every chapter in this guide teaches you to read one of those signals. Once you can read them, you'll rarely need a schedule, and you'll rarely lose a plant.

CHAPTER 2

Light: The Thing Nobody Measures

Light is food for a plant. It's also the factor people guess at most and measure least.

Your eyes are lying to you

Human eyes adapt to dim conditions so well that a room can feel bright while being far darker than a plant needs. A spot two metres (about six feet) from a window can get only a small fraction of the light at the glass, even though it looks nearly as bright to you.

Plant light is measured in **lux** or **foot-candles**. You don't need to become an expert, but a rough sense of the scale makes everything else make sense:

Location	Rough light level
Directly in a sunny window	Very bright, often 10,000+ lux in direct sun
Right beside a bright window, no direct sun	Bright indirect, roughly 2,000–5,000 lux
A few steps back into the room	Medium, roughly 500–2,000 lux
Across the room or in a hallway	Low, often under 500 lux

These are rough ranges, not precise numbers. Light varies hugely with season, weather, window size, trees outside and what's across the street. The pattern is what matters: **light falls off fast with distance from the window.**

The shadow test

No meter? Use your hand, at midday, where the plant will sit.

- **A sharp, clearly defined shadow:** bright light, and possibly direct sun.
- **A soft shadow with blurry edges:** medium, indirect light. Right for most tropical houseplants.
- **A faint shadow you can barely see:** low light. Only the toughest plants will cope.
- **No shadow at all:** not enough light for any plant to thrive long-term.

A free light meter app on your phone gives a better rough reading than guessing. Readings aren't lab-accurate, but they're more than good enough to compare spots in your home.

Window direction

For homes in the **Northern Hemisphere**:

- **South-facing:** the strongest light, often with direct sun for much of the day. Great for cacti and succulents. Can scorch many tropicals right at the glass, so set them back a little or filter with a sheer curtain.
- **West-facing:** strong, hot afternoon sun. Good light, but watch for scorching in summer.
- **East-facing:** gentle morning sun, softer afternoons. The best window for most houseplants.
- **North-facing:** no direct sun and the least light. Fine for low-light plants, but a real struggle for anything that wants bright light.

In the **Southern Hemisphere**, swap north and south.

What "bright indirect light" actually means

This phrase is on most plant labels, and it confuses almost everyone.

It means **a spot with lots of light, where the sun's rays don't land directly on the leaves for long.** Near a bright window, but not in the sunbeam. Or in the sunbeam only for an hour or two of gentle morning sun.

For most tropical houseplants (monstera, pothos, philodendron, calathea, fiddle leaf fig), that means within a metre or so of an east window, or set back slightly from a south or west one.

Signs your plant needs more light

- **Leggy growth:** long, stretched stems with big gaps between leaves
- **Leaning hard** toward the window
- **Small new leaves**, smaller than the old ones
- **Variegation fading:** patterned leaves turning plain green
- **No new growth** during spring and summer
- **Soil staying wet for a week or more** after watering (very common, and a major overwatering risk)

Signs of too much direct sun

- **Bleached, pale or washed-out patches** on leaves facing the window
- **Crispy brown scorch marks** that appear suddenly after a move
- **Leaves curling** or folding up during the hottest part of the day

Sunburn damage doesn't recover. The marked leaf stays marked, but new leaves will be fine once the plant is moved.

Grow lights

If your home is genuinely dark, grow lights are cheap and effective, and they've become much more attractive than they used to be.

- **Choose full-spectrum LED.** They look close to normal white light, run cool, and use little electricity.
- **Distance matters.** Follow the manufacturer's guidance. As a rough starting point, many household grow bulbs work at 15–60 cm (6–24 inches) above the plant.
- **Run them on a timer** for around 12–14 hours a day. Plants need darkness too.
- **Watch the plant.** Bleaching means too close or too strong. Stretching means too far or too weak.

A grow light turns a dim bookshelf into a spot where almost any beginner plant can thrive.

> **The rule of thumb**
> When in doubt, move the plant closer to the window. Far more houseplants die from too little light than too much.

CHAPTER 3

Water: The Number One Killer

If you learn one skill from this guide, learn this one.

Why overwatering kills

Healthy soil is a mix of solid particles, water and **air**. Roots breathe the oxygen in those air pockets. Water a plant too often and those pockets never drain. Roots suffocate, start to die, and rot-causing fungi and bacteria move in.

A plant with rotting roots **can't take up water**. So it droops, yellows and wilts, which looks exactly like thirst. The owner waters again. That's the loop that kills more houseplants than anything else.

Never water on a schedule

"Water once a week" is the most common and most harmful piece of plant advice there is.

How fast a plant uses water depends on:

- **Light:** more light means faster drinking
- **Season:** much slower in winter
- **Temperature and humidity**
- **Pot size and material:** small pots and terracotta dry fastest
- **Soil mix:** chunky mixes dry faster than dense ones
- **The plant itself:** a succulent and a fern need completely different things

The same plant might need water every four days in a bright summer window and every three weeks in a dim winter corner. A fixed schedule is wrong for most of the year.

Water on a condition, not on a calendar. Check the plant, then decide.

How to check whether a plant needs water

The finger test. Push a finger into the soil up to the second knuckle, about 5 cm (2 inches). Dry at that depth? Most tropical plants are ready. Still damp? Wait and check again in a few days.

The chopstick test. Push a plain wooden chopstick or skewer to the bottom of the pot, leave it a minute, pull it out. Dark and damp, or coming out with soil stuck to it, means it's still wet down low, which your finger can't reach. Clean and dry means it's time. Great for bigger pots.

The weight test. Lift the pot right after a thorough watering, and again when it's dry. After a few rounds you'll feel the difference instantly. This is the fastest method once you've learned

it, especially for small and medium pots.

Moisture meters can help, but cheap ones are often unreliable. Treat them as a second opinion rather than the answer.

How much each plant wants

Most beginner houseplants fall into three groups:

Group	When to water	Examples
Let it dry out completely	When the soil is dry all the way through	Snake plant, ZZ plant, succulents, cacti
Let the top dry out	When the top 2–5 cm (1–2 in) is dry	Pothos, monstera, philodendron, rubber plant, fiddle leaf fig
Keep lightly moist	When the surface just starts to feel dry	Calathea, ferns, peace lily

When in doubt, **treat the plant as one group drier than you think.** Recovering an underwatered plant is usually easy. Recovering an overwatered one often isn't.

How to water properly

Water thoroughly, then let it drain. Pour slowly until water runs out of the drainage holes, then let it drain completely. A good soak followed by a proper dry-out is far healthier than frequent small sips, which keep the top wet and the roots shallow.

Tip out saucers and decorative pots. Roots left standing in water are the fastest route to rot. Check the saucer 15–30 minutes after watering and empty it.

Bottom watering is a good option for plants with dense foliage or soil that's become water-repellent. Stand the pot in a few centimetres of water for 15–30 minutes until the top of the soil darkens, then let it drain fully.

Room-temperature water is kinder than very cold water, especially for tropical plants.

The decorative pot trap

Many plants are sold in a plain plastic nursery pot that sits inside a nice ceramic pot with **no drainage hole**. That's fine, as long as you know it's happening.

The danger is water collecting invisibly at the bottom of the outer pot, with the nursery pot's roots sitting in it. Always **lift the inner pot out after watering** and tip away any water, or water the plant in the sink and put it back once it has drained.

If a pot has no drainage hole and your plant is planted straight into it, that's the single most likely reason it will die. Chapter 5 covers what to do about it.

Tap water

For most houseplants, ordinary tap water is fine.

A few plants, calathea being the best known, are sensitive to minerals and chlorine, which shows up as brown, crispy leaf edges. For those, filtered water, rainwater or distilled water can help. Letting tap water stand overnight lets some chlorine dissipate, though it won't remove everything.

Over time, minerals and fertiliser salts can build up as a white crust on the soil or the pot. Chapter 6 covers how to flush them out.

> **The underwatering myth**
> Beginners worry about forgetting to water. A plant that's slightly too dry droops, you water it, and within hours it recovers. A plant with rotten roots often doesn't. Forgetting is forgivable. Fussing isn't.

What's In The Full Guide

This sample covered the first three chapters. The complete guide continues with:

- **Humidity, temperature and airflow**, including why misting doesn't work
- **Soil, pots and repotting**, and why a gravel layer makes drainage worse
- **Feeding**, and when not to
- **The diagnostic**: what yellow leaves, brown tips, drooping and leggy growth actually mean
- **Root rot rescue**: a step-by-step emergency protocol
- **Pests without panic**: fungus gnats, spider mites, mealybugs, scale, thrips and aphids
- **Pet and child safety**: which common houseplants are toxic, based on the ASPCA database, and the lily warning every cat owner needs
- **Twelve plant profiles**, from pothos and snake plant to fiddle leaf fig and calathea
- **Buying plants that survive**, seasons, and going on holiday
- **Propagation** as your safety net
- **The ten most common mistakes**
- **A 30-day plant reset plan**

Printable extras: light map worksheet, watering log, diagnostic cheat sheet, and care cards for all twelve plants.